Duplicate Finder

User manual

A guide to finding duplicate files, grouping similar photos and gathering scattered images — without the risk of losing anything, because the application never deletes your originals and everything can be undone.

Desktop application for Windows · Python + CustomTkinter
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1. What this application does

This manual explains how to use **Duplicate Finder**, the application I built to tidy up my files, mostly my photos, and which can now help you too. It has three functions, one per tab:

Tab	What it is for
Exact duplicates	Finds files that are identical byte for byte (the same photo or document saved several times) and lets you keep just one copy.
Similar photos	Finds the same photo saved several times even when it is not identical: recompressed, at a lower resolution or with a colour filter.
Gather images	Puts all the photos you have scattered across a folder and its subfolders into a single folder.

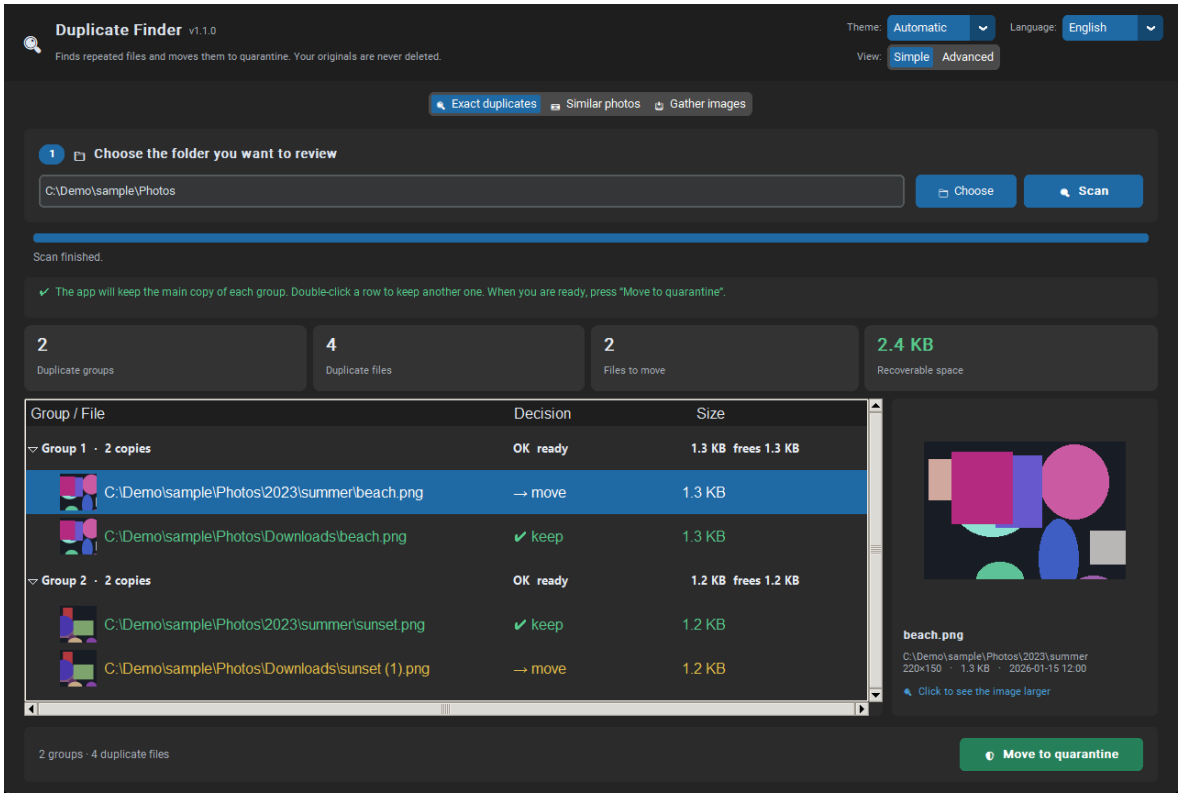
Note. The golden rule I set myself: **the application never deletes or modifies your original files**. It only reads them and, when you confirm, *moves* them to another folder. Any operation can also be undone from the “History”.

2. Installation and first start

- There is nothing to install. Download `Buscador-de-duplicados.exe` (a single file: copy it wherever you like and double-click it) or, if your antivirus blocks it or takes long, `Buscador-de-duplicados-portable.zip`: unzip it into a folder with a short path (for example `C:\Apps`) and open the .exe inside.
- It needs no internet connection and no administrator rights.
- The first time it starts in **Simple view**. The view you choose is remembered for next time.
- The interface is in English or Spanish. It follows the language of Windows, and the **Language** selector in the header changes it (it applies the next time you open the app).

Windows may show an “unknown publisher” warning the first time (because the executable is not signed). That is normal for small programs; click “More info” and “Run anyway”.

3. The main window



Simple view, “Exact duplicates” tab, after a scan.

At the top right there are three settings:

- **Theme**: *Automatic* (follows the Windows theme), *Light* or *Dark*. It applies immediately and is remembered for next time.
- **Language**: English or Spanish (applies the next time you open the app).
- **View — Simple / Advanced**:
- **Simple**: the minimum — choose a folder, scan and move. The application decides by itself which copy to keep in each group.
- **Advanced**: everything appears — scan filters, preferred folder, export to CSV, the sensitivity slider, and the “History” button.

Right below are the three tabs. Switching tabs does not lose what you have in the others.

> **Note.** Disabled buttons look dull grey (not red or green): it means that action is not available yet, not that there is an error.

4. The “Exact duplicates” tab

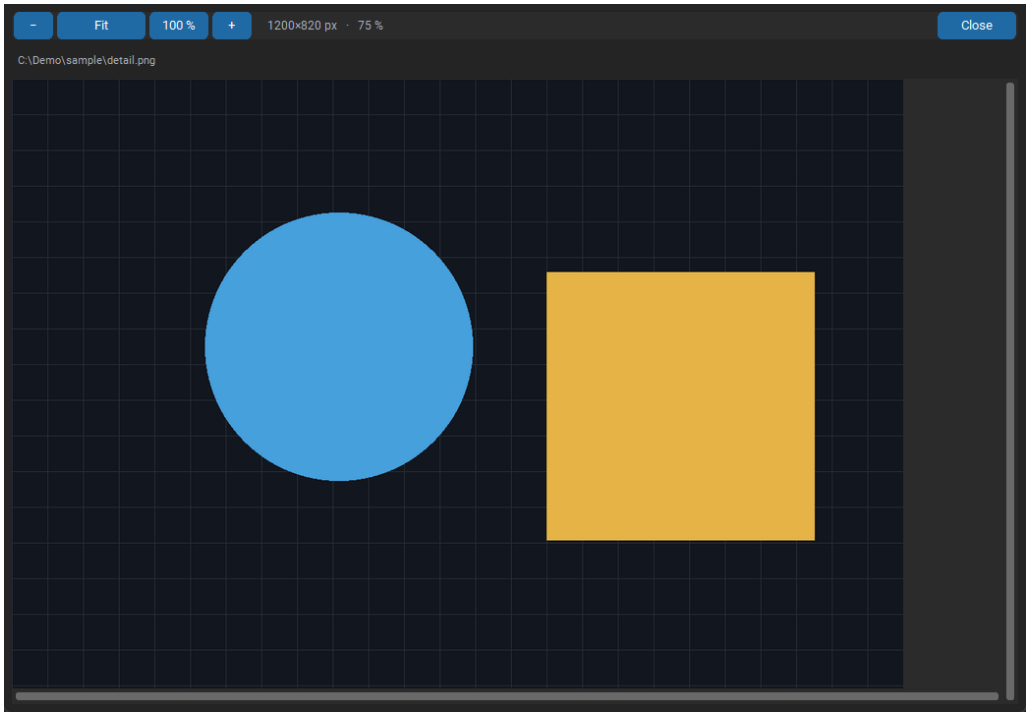
4.1. Basic use (Simple view)

- **1.** Click “Choose” and select the folder you want to review (for example your photos folder or a whole disk).
- **2.** Click “Scan”. The progress bar shows two stages: first it checks sizes, then it computes fingerprints.
- **3.** When it finishes you see the groups of duplicates. The application has already marked in each group the **main copy** to keep (the one with the least “copy-like” name, in the least nested and oldest folder) and the rest to move.
- **4.** Review. If you want to keep another copy in a group, **double-click** its row.
- **5.** Click “Move to quarantine”, choose a folder (it must be **outside** the one you scanned) and confirm.

The statistics panel shows how many groups there are, how many duplicate files, how many would be moved and how much space you would recover.

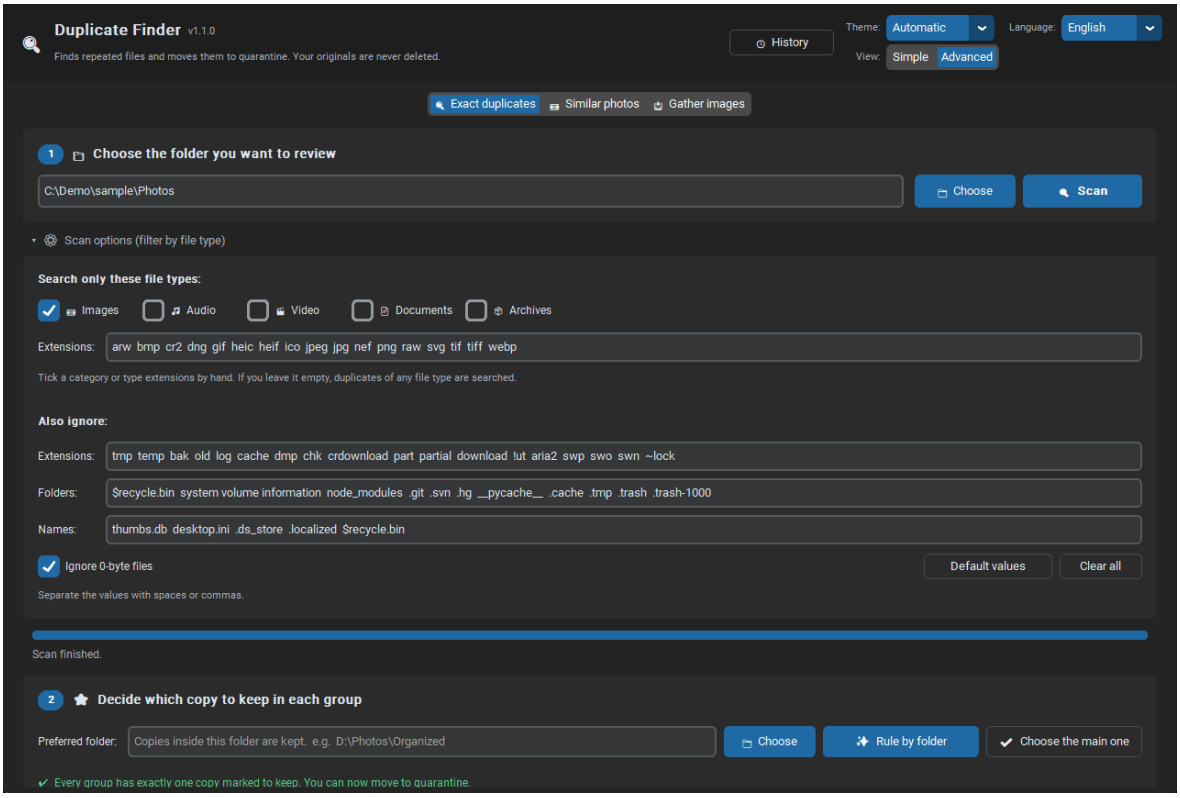
4.2. Preview and full-size view

When you select a file in the list, its preview appears on the right (the image, or a box with the extension if it is not an image) with its name, path, size, date and resolution. **Click the preview** to open the image almost full screen, with zoom (mouse wheel or buttons) and panning by dragging.



The image viewer: wheel to zoom, drag to move, “Fit” to fit it in the window.

4.3. Scan options (Advanced view)



The “Scan options” panel expanded, with “Images” ticked.

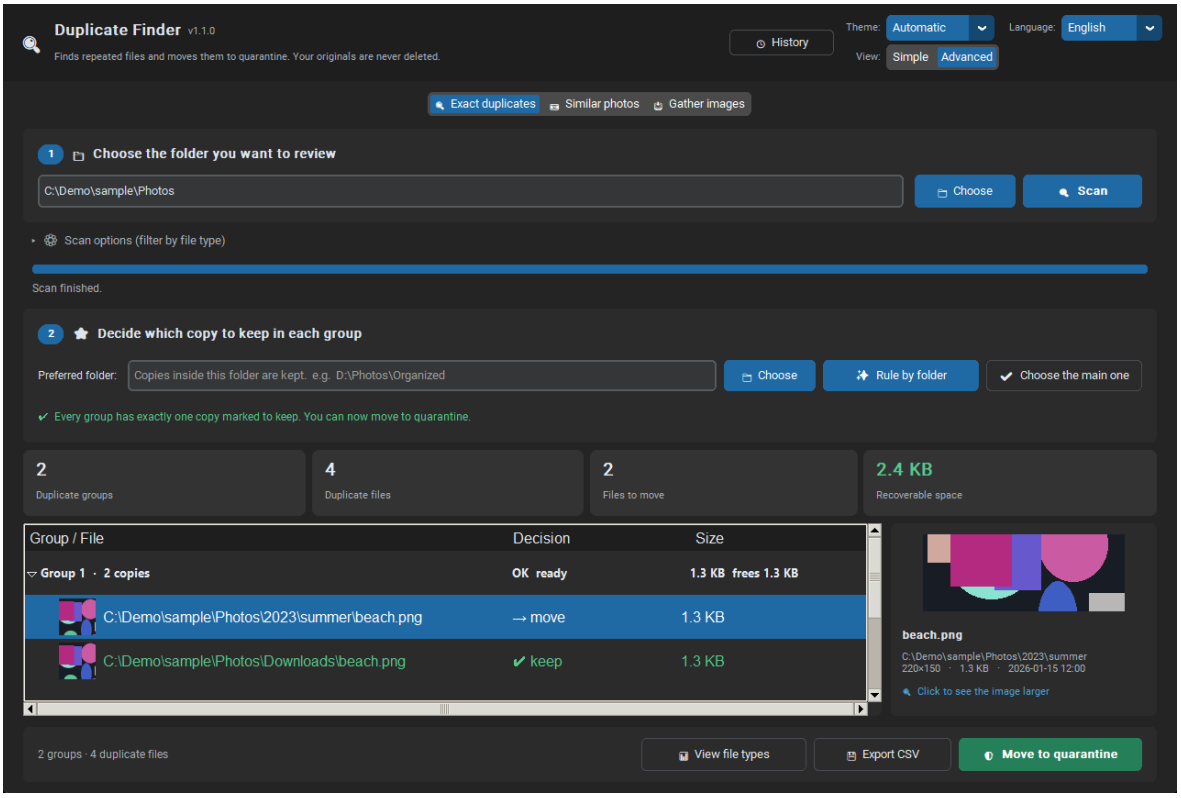
Search only these file types

Tick one or more categories (Images, Audio, Video, Documents, Archives) and the extensions field fills itself in. You can also type extensions by hand. If you leave it empty, duplicates of any type are searched.

Also ignore

Discards junk before scanning: extensions (`tmp`, `log`...), folders (`node_modules`, `$RECYCLE.BIN`...), names (`Thumbs.db`...) and 0-byte files. It comes with reasonable values. What is ignored is not even read, so the scan is faster.

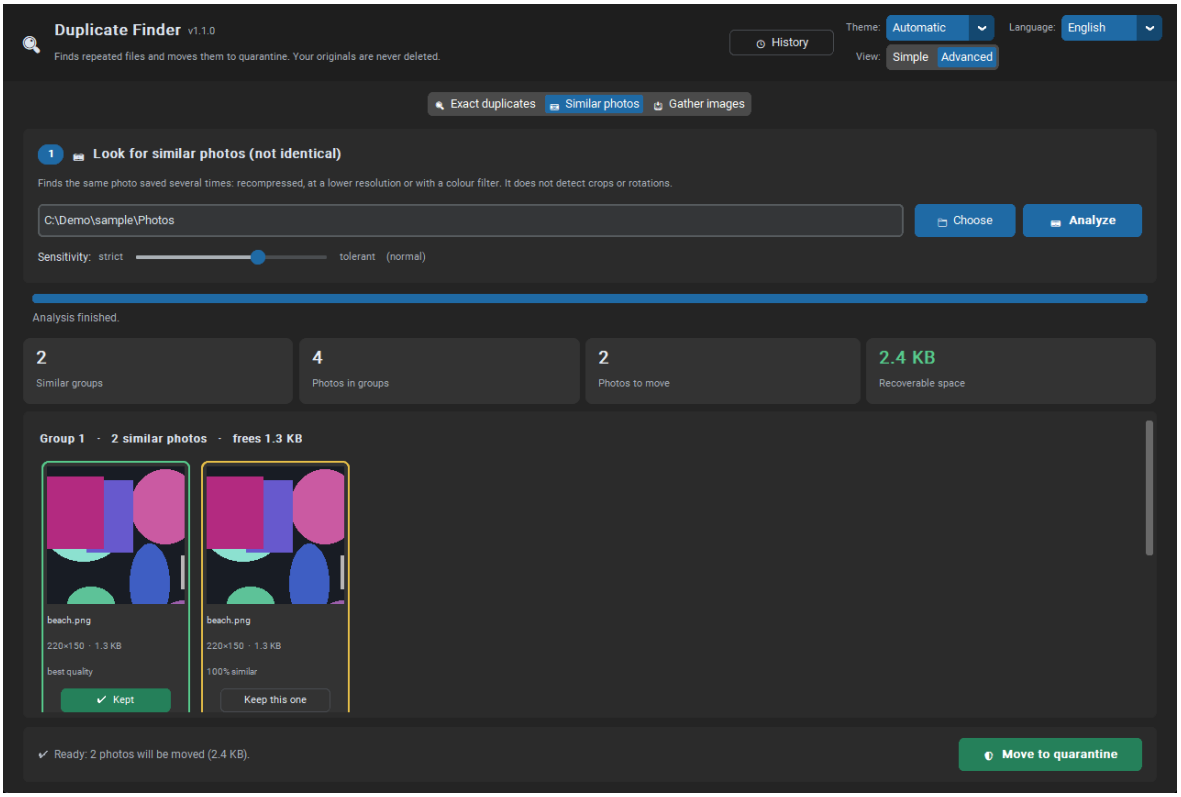
4.4. Choosing what to keep (Advanced view)



Advanced view: “Preferred folder”, “Rule by folder”, “Choose the main one”, “View file types” and “Export CSV” come back.

- **Preferred folder + “Rule by folder”**: enter a folder (for example `D:\Photos\Organized`) and click the button. In each group, if there is a copy inside that folder, that one is kept. Groups without any copy there are highlighted so you decide by hand.
- **“Choose the main one”**: applies the same automatic preselection as the Simple view.
- **Working with the table**: one click selects (and shows the preview); a click on the “Decision” column toggles keep/move for that file; a double-click leaves that copy as the only one to keep.
- **“View file types”**: shows the duplicates grouped by extension with their weight, to decide what to add to the filter.
- **“Export CSV”**: saves the full report to a file.

5. The “Similar photos” tab



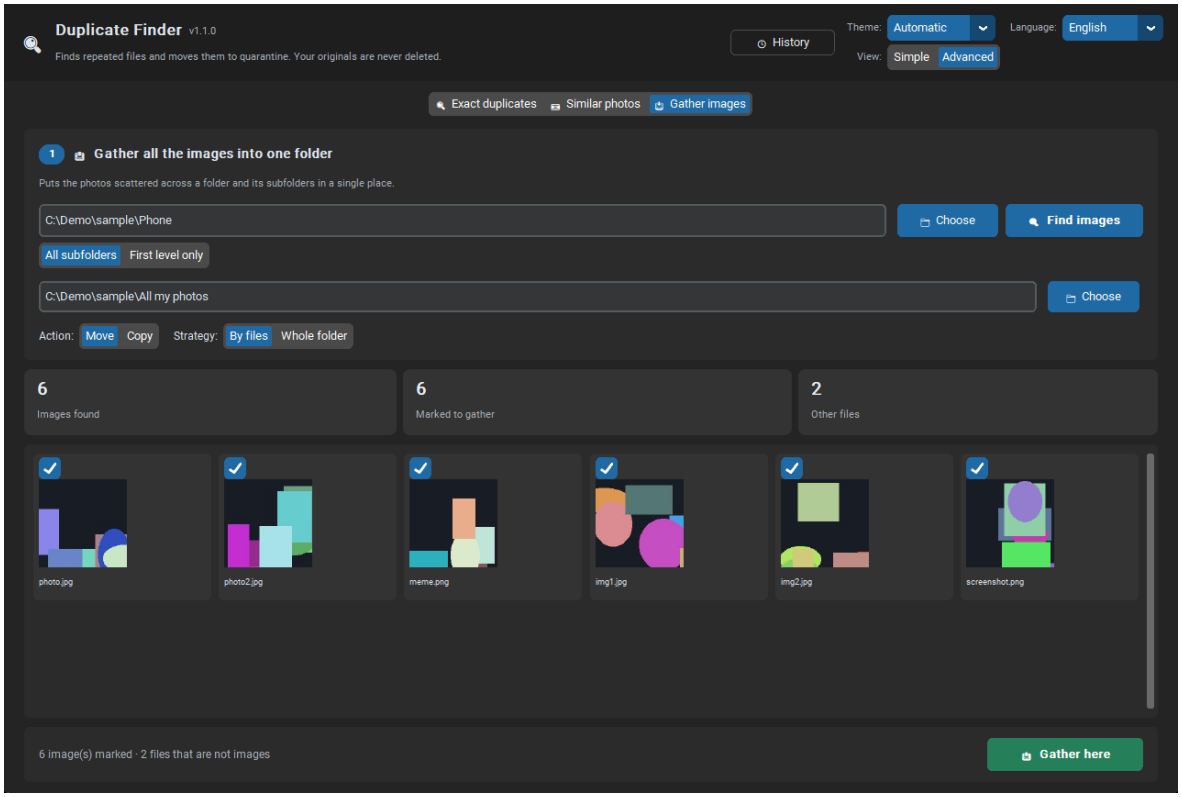
Each group shows the similar photos with their thumbnail, resolution, size and percentage of similarity.

- **1.** Choose the folder and click “Analyze”.
- **2.** The **Sensitivity** slider (Advanced view) controls how alike two photos must be to count as the same group: “strict” groups fewer, “tolerant” groups more.
- **3.** In each group, the first photo is the **best quality** (highest resolution) and it is marked to keep. If you prefer another one, click “Keep this one” below it.
- **4.** Click a thumbnail to see the photo large and compare.
- **5.** If there are many groups they are split into pages: use “Previous” and “Next” under the list. What you decide on each page is kept.
- **6.** “Move to quarantine” moves the unmarked photos from **all** the pages.

5.1. What it finds and what it does not

It finds	It does not find
The same photo recompressed or at lower quality	Cropped photos
The same photo resized (smaller)	Rotated or flipped photos
The same photo with a colour or brightness filter	A piece of a collage
The same photo with a watermark in a corner	

6. The “Gather images” tab



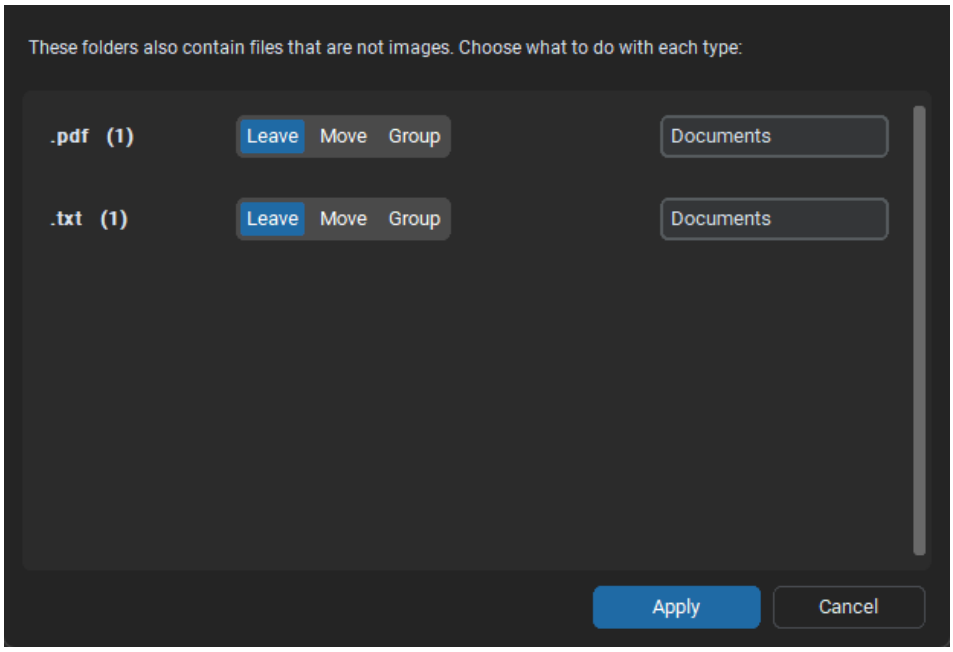
List of the images found, with a checkbox to exclude any of them.

- **1.** Choose the folder to review. The **“All subfolders” / “First level only”** selector decides whether it searches in depth or only what sits loose in the folder.
- **2.** Click “Find images”. They appear with their thumbnail; untick the ones you do not want to take.
- **3.** Choose the **common destination folder**.
- **4.** (Advanced view) Choose **Move** (removes them from the source) or **Copy** (keeps the originals), and the strategy:

Strategy	What it does
By files	Each image goes to destination/*same subfolder*. For example “holidays/beach.jpg” ends up in “destination/holidays/beach.jpg”.
Whole folder	Moves or copies the folder you are reviewing in full (with everything inside it) to “destination/FolderName/”.

6.1. Files that are not images

If those folders also hold documents, music, etc., and you use the “By files” strategy, this dialog appears:

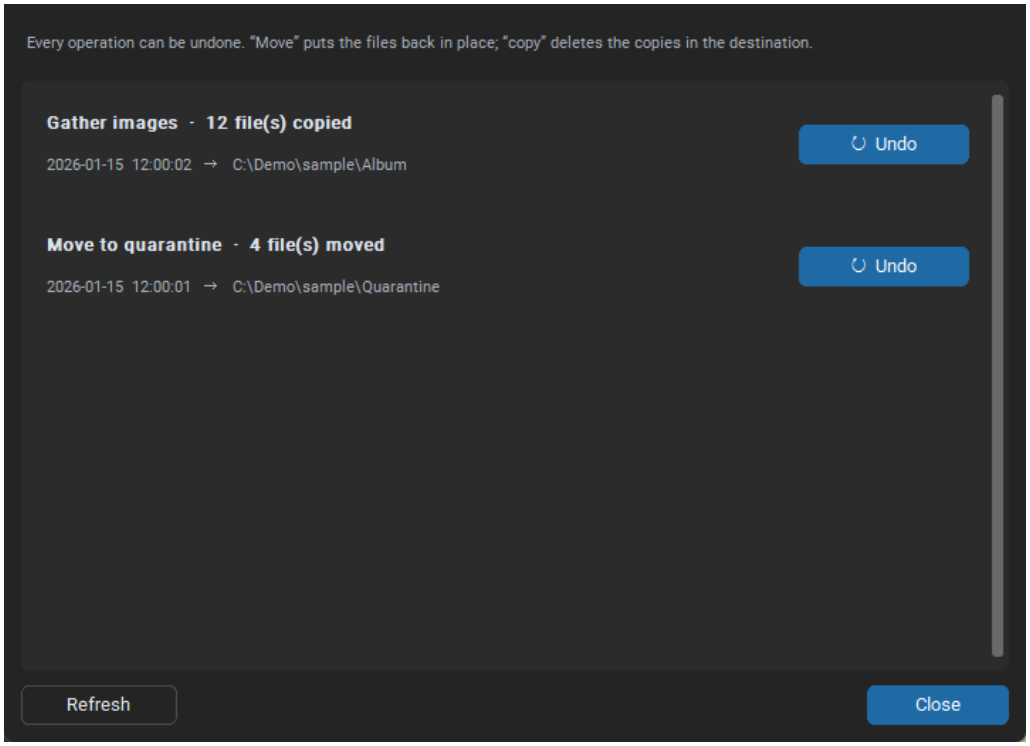


For each file type you choose what to do.

- **Leave**: it is not moved, it stays where it is.
- **Move**: it goes to the destination with its same subfolder, like the images.
- **Group**: all the files of that type go to a folder with the name you type (for example “Documents”), keeping the subfolders inside.

7. History and undo

In **Advanced view**, the **“History”** button in the header opens this window from any tab:



Every move or copy operation is recorded, with its “Undo” button.

- If the operation was a **move**, “Undo” puts every file back in its original location. If something already exists at that path, it warns you and overwrites nothing.
- If the operation was a **copy**, “Undo” deletes the copies in the destination (with a clear confirmation). It is the only case in which the application deletes anything, and only files it created itself.

The history is saved in `%APPDATA%\BuscadorDuplicados\history.json` and keeps the latest operations.

8. The quarantine folder and the logs

- You choose the quarantine folder (or the destination folder, in “Gather images”) every time. There is no fixed one.
- Inside it the subfolder structure of the source is recreated, so you know where each file came from.
- A CSV is written (`_log_quarantine_DATE.csv` or `_log_gather_DATE.csv`) with the source and destination of each file, in case you prefer to review or undo by hand.
- Nothing is deleted: review that folder at your leisure and delete yourself whatever you no longer need.

9. Tips and frequently asked questions

Question	Answer
Can it delete my photos by accident?	Not your originals. It only moves files, and always after a confirmation. Everything can be undone from the History. The only time it deletes anything is when you undo a copy: it removes the copies it created itself, and asks for confirmation first.
I got an “unexpected error” notice. What do I do?	The application writes what happened to a text file: `%APPDATA%\BuscadorDuplicados\logs\app.log` (paste that path into Explorer and open it with Notepad). You can keep using the application, and your files have not been touched. If the failure repeats, close and reopen it; if you want to report the problem, attach that file.
I moved things and I see empty folders at the source.	That is normal: the files inside were moved, not the folders. The empty folder stays; you can delete it yourself if you want.
The scan takes very long.	Use the “Search only these file types” filter (for example Images) or narrow the folder. The first pass (sizes) is fast; the time goes into computing fingerprints of large files.
What is the difference between the first two tabs?	“Exact duplicates” looks for identical files; “Similar photos” looks for the same photo even if it was re-saved with another quality or filter.
Can it be used on an external or network drive?	Yes. Keep in mind that moving between different drives is slower (it copies and then deletes the original).